

CCDesigner — Podcast Cue Cards

Read the question, glance down at the beats, speak in your own words. Bold idea = the point. Ø=Ü¬ = say close to verbatim.

&“ THE 4 ANCHORS (fall back here if you lose your thread)

1. Teaching is product design with a live audience
2. The gap isn't quality — it's the last mile
3. AI does the admin, never the artistry
4. For some kids, the arts lesson is the reason they come in

YOUR JOURNEY & PHILOSOPHY

Q Teacher + builder — how do those identities feed each other? Does the classroom make you a better designer?

- Same instinct, not two jobs — teaching is product design with a live audience that tells you instantly when something doesn't work.
- 20 years = thousands of lessons watched land or flop !' I don't guess what a teacher needs, I AM that 7am Monday teacher.
- Classroom keeps me honest — teachers can smell a tool built by someone who's never held 30 Year 8s on a wet Friday.

Ø=Ü“Every feature has to survive contact with a real classroom, or it doesn't ship.”

Q Arts lessons never becoming passive — what's the worst vs. best version?

- Worst: 30 kids on a worksheet about crotchets & quavers — learning ABOUT music, never making any. Drama = reading a play from desks.
- Best: loud, slightly chaotic, everyone DOING — call-and-response, improvisation, kids making real creative choices.
- My design rule: the tool should pull you toward the active version, not the safe one.

Ø=Ü“If the easiest lesson to plan is also the most passive, the tool has failed.”

THE EDTECH TOOLS

Q What frustrated you enough to build Assessify yourself?

- Arts assessment was either non-existent or borrowed wholesale from maths — didn't fit.
- Spent evenings bending spreadsheets into something that could capture progress in performance — miserable, reductive.
- Nobody was building for us !' eventually you stop waiting and build it.

Ø=Ü“Nobody was building for the arts, so I stopped waiting.”

Q How do you quantify creativity without crushing it?

- You DON'T quantify the creativity — that's the trap.
- Assess the process & progression instead: Is the child taking more risks? Listening better in an ensemble? Refining work after feedback?
- The art stays unquantified; the development is what you track.

Ø=Ü“We measure the growth, never the spark.”

Q PeriFeedback — tell us about peripatetic teaching and why it needed its own tool.

- Peripatetic teachers = the invisible workforce of music education.
- Travel school to school, often one child at a time, no shared records, no loop back to classroom teacher or parent.
- Runs on goodwill and scraps of paper — most EdTech assumes a full-time teacher in one building, so they fall through the gap.

Ø=Ü“They hold up music education and nobody built them a single tool — until now.”

CCDESIGNER & THE BIGGER VISION (CORE OF THE EPISODE — TAKE YOUR TIME)

Q Why the gap between LSO / Royal Opera House resources and teachers using them? Why

unsolved?

- The resources are genuinely world-class — and they sit unused.
- Not a quality problem — a last-mile / adaptation problem: a beautiful 40-page PDF arrives when a teacher has 20 mins and needs a lesson for tomorrow, their class, their level.
- Unsolved because the fix isn't glamorous — it's the unsexy work of making great content findable, adaptable, droppable into a plan.

Ø=Ü *"The gap isn't quality. It's the last mile."*

Q Are Stacks like wiki pages — living documents? How do you stop them getting messy?

- Yes, fair model — Stacks evolve as more teachers use & contribute.
- Stay clean because they're NOT fully open like Wikipedia: structure underneath (every activity curriculum-mapped, so contributions slot into a shape).
- Keep a curated "spine" version distinct from community variations branching off it — core stays clean, experimentation lives on the edges.

Ø=Ü *"Wikipedia with a backbone — the structure keeps it from sprawling."*

Q Who has editorial control over a Stack — creator, school, or community?

- Layered. Creator keeps authorship of the original.
- A school can hold a private, controlled version for its own staff.
- Community layer = forks & contributions, but those are suggestions, not silent overwrites.

Ø=Ü *"The creator owns the trunk; the community owns the branches."*

Q Will teachers actually contribute, or is there a free-rider risk?

- Most will consume — that's fine, not a failure (true of every community platform).
- Design for the generous minority; make consuming valuable on its own.
- Lower the cost of contributing to one tap (because you already built it in the tool).
- Marketplace adds incentive — practitioners can sell packs, so contributing can be income, not just altruism.

Ø=Ü *"Make sharing one tap, and far more people do it."*

Q Is there a Wikipedia moment you're hoping for?

- Yes — that's the bet.
- Right now every arts teacher solves the same problems alone, in parallel, thousands of times over.
- It tips when opening CCDesigner is genuinely faster than starting from scratch !' each new contribution makes it more valuable for everyone (network effect = the long game).

Ø=Ü *"Thousands of teachers solving the same problem alone — we just connect the work."*

Q Five-year success — free public good, business, or something else?

- Both — and they're not in tension.
- Core = a free, genuinely useful public good: every UK teacher able to plan a great arts lesson for nothing.
- Sustainability = the layer on top: marketplace, premium institutional features, partnerships with the orgs making those brilliant resources.

Ø=Ü *"Arts Council support lets us build the free thing properly — so it's actually good, not a crippled trial."*

AI IN ARTS EDUCATION

Q Where's the line — using AI to support teachers without automating the artistry?

- Simple rule: AI handles the admin, never the artistry.
- It suggests a warm-up, adapts an activity for additional needs, saves an hour of planning.
- It NEVER decides what's creatively good, and NEVER stands between a teacher and a child.

Ø=Ü *"A planning assistant — not a substitute teacher, and definitely not a substitute artist."*

Q One AI use that excites you, one that worries you?

- Excites: instant personalised adaptation — SEND variations + stretch tasks that used to take hours, ready in

seconds, every child pitched right.

- Worries: AI flattening everything to a competent, soulless average — kids handing in AI-polished “creative” work with no creativity in it, teachers losing the muscle of inventing.

Ø=Ü“*The dream is every child gets the right lesson. The fear is every child gets the same one.*”

THE STATE OF ARTS EDUCATION

Q Optimistic or pessimistic about the next ten years for UK arts education?

- Stubbornly optimistic, but clear-eyed — arts are always first on the chopping block when budgets tighten.
- Tide on wellbeing, creativity & “what is education FOR” is slowly turning.
- My optimism is active, not passive — it’s why I build.

Ø=Ü“*Make great arts teaching cheaper and shareable, and you make it harder to cut.*”

Q What do you wish school leaders understood about your department?

- “Just a drama lesson” is often where the quiet child speaks for the first time, where a struggling reader finds confidence, where a class learns to collaborate.
- Outcomes don’t show in the data like maths does — but they’re load-bearing for everything else.

Ø=Ü“*We’re not the enrichment add-on. For some kids, we’re the reason they come in at all.*”

FUN CLOSER

Q Who was your most influential music teacher?

- [NAME] — [one specific story].
- Go specific, not sentimental: the teacher who let you be terrible until you weren’t, or who took you seriously before you’d earned it.
- Ø=Ü↪ [Your line here]

Ø>Ýí Mid-flow reminders

- Bring every abstract point back to one real child or one real Monday.
- Don’t over-explain Stacks !’ “living lesson documents teachers build on together,” then move on.
- Let the emotional beats sit — don’t rush the “quiet child” line.

